

HEART MURMURS IN THE NEWBORN

INFORMATION FOR PARENTS

What is a heart murmur?

A heart murmur is an extra whooshing noise which is heard when the heart is listened to with a stethoscope.

Does a heart murmur mean there is heart problem?

No. Most babies with heart murmurs have completely normal hearts. These babies have what are known as “innocent” or “normal” heart murmurs. However, sometimes a heart murmur can be a sign that there is a problem with the heart like a small hole or a narrowing and this is why all babies with heart murmurs are reviewed.

How will I know if my baby has a heart problem?

Your baby will be seen in neonatal clinic within 4-6 weeks. If the murmur can still be heard and the doctor is not sure that it is an “innocent” or “normal” heart murmur then your baby will be referred to a heart specialist who may do further tests.

What should I look out for?

Most babies with heart murmurs remain well but if your baby becomes unwell they should be seen urgently by a doctor. Signs to look out for include: breathing difficulties; breathless or sweaty when feeding; poor feeding; blue colour of skin and lips or mottled skin.

What should I do if my baby becomes unwell?

You should seek urgent medical advice. Phone _____. Explain that your baby has a heart murmur and has become unwell.

Points to remember

A heart murmur is an extra noise heard when listening with a stethoscope.
Most babies with heart murmurs have completely normal hearts.
A heart murmur can sometimes be a sign of an underlying heart problem.
IF YOUR BABY BECOMES UNWELL SEEK URGENT MEDICAL ADVICE.

